docdesigner: Alpha Testing

Instructions for participants — version 0.11.0

Joseph N. Cohen
Queens College, CUNY

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ABSTRACT

Thank you for taking a look at docdesigner. This alpha asks two questions and only two: **does it work on your machine and your documents, and is it easy to learn?** Comments on how the styles look are welcome too. Please read "What we already know about" on page 3 before you start, so you don't spend time on known issues. Setup and the first task take about fifteen minutes.

1 What this is

`docdesigner` renders R Markdown into publication-quality PDFs. A **style** is a small file of design tokens — typefaces, colours, spacing, rules — that the engine turns into a typeset page. The promise is *same content, any style*: you point one document at a different style and it re-typesets, without your touching a word of the prose.

Sixteen styles ship, in two sets. `academic` holds `minimal`, `modern`, `nature`, `methods`, `demography`, `ssrn`, `sociology`, `ajs`, `thesis` and `qc-thesis`. `public` holds `policy`, `government`, `economist`, `atlantic`, `humanities` and `bulletin`.

This document was itself typeset by docdesigner, in the `methods` style.

2 Setup

You need R, a LaTeX installation providing `xelatex`, and pandoc. RStudio bundles pandoc; TinyTeX and MiKTeX both work for LaTeX. If you have knitted an R Markdown document to PDF before, you already have all three.

```
# install.packages("remotes")
remotes::install_github("jncohen/docdesigner")

library(docdesigner)
designer_check()      # reports anything missing from the toolchain
designer_styles()     # the sixteen styles, with their sets
```

If `designer_check()` reports a problem, fix that before going further. Nearly every confusing failure downstream is a missing `xelatex` or a missing font.

Please tell us how this step went even if it went fine — how long it took, and whether anything was unclear. Installation is the step most likely to lose a new user, and it is the one we can least easily test ourselves.

3 What to try

Three tasks, in order. The second is the important one.

3.1 Render something

Make a new R Markdown document, or take any small one you have, and put this at the top:

```yaml
---
title: "Anything at all"
author: "Your Name"
output:
  docdesigner::pdf:
    style: minimal
---
```

Knit it. That is the whole interface — one line names the style. If this produces a PDF, the package works on your machine.

3.2 Render a real document of your own

This is what we most need. Take a genuine paper, report or memo of yours — the messier the better, ideally one with sections, tables, figures, footnotes and a bibliography — and render it. Then change that one `style:` line and render it again, three or four times:

```yaml
output:
  docdesigner::pdf:
    style: nature      # then sociology, humanities, ssrn, ...
```

We want to know whether **your content survives the switch**. Tables that overflow the page, figures that land in the wrong column, citations that stop resolving, headings that collide with the running head, code that runs off the edge — that is the failure class we cannot find on our own test documents, because our test documents are tidy and yours are real.

Note that `nature` and `economist` are two-column. Wide tables and long code lines are the usual casualty there, and we would like to know how badly.

3.3 Install a style set

```
designer_install_set("academic")
designer_sets()
```

Sets install to your R user directory and survive package updates. This checks that distribution works from a machine that is not ours.

4 What we most want to hear

Beyond outright breakage, the thing we cannot see from here is **where you got stuck**. Specifically:

- What did you have to look up, guess at, or read twice?
- What did you expect to exist and not find?
- Did anything behave differently from how you assumed it would?
- How long did the whole thing take, start to finish?

"I assumed X and it turned out to be Y" is a more useful report than most bug reports. Please send those even when nothing was broken.

5 What we already know about

The styles are designed and every one renders. **Please do comment on how they look.**

Some things are known and do not need reporting:

1. Tables in `nature`, `economist` and `bulletin` move. In a two-column style every table is placed by LaTeX, often after the paragraph that follows it, and a table wider than a column goes to the top of the next page.

2. `minimal` changed in 0.10.0. It is now the plain look of an unstyled R Markdown PDF. The clean preprint style it used to be is now called `modern`.

One thing that is intentional rather than unfinished: **fonts substitute.** Proprietary typefaces are replaced by bundled open ones — XITS for Times, EB Garamond for oldstyle, Source Serif 4 for various. A style being "not quite the real typeface" is expected. A substitution that looks *wrong at the size used* is worth telling us about.

6 How to report

Email **josephncohen@gmail.com**, one message per problem, with `docdesigner alpha` in the subject line.

What makes a report actionable, in rough order of value:

1. **Attach the PDF**, or a screenshot of the part that went wrong. We cannot judge a layout problem from a description.
2. **Which style**, and whether other styles do the same thing. "`sociology` only" and "all sixteen" are different bugs.
3. **A small `.Rmd` that reproduces it.** If your document is confidential, cut it down until it is not — that usually localises the problem anyway.
4. **The output of `designer_check()`**, and of `sessionInfo()`.
5. **What you expected instead.**

If something failed to install, send the full console output, including the error. That is usually enough on its own.